

September_17_Open_Notebook_2

Reading Notes:

- What data "counts"
 - Data is shaped by what researchers choose to include/exclude.
 - Data has rigid and explicit boundaries.
 - Categories determine who/what is represented.
 - Example: only having "male" or "female" options excludes a large portion of people who are clicking on your website.
 - Key question: who decides what counts as data, and who/what gets left out?
 - Also, as researchers, you have to have boundaries on your own research (especially in history) so as to not have too large a dataset.
 - Example: if you're researching English Kings and their relation to religion, you may want to choose a specific time period or religion. Knowing that it removes a certain aspect of the overall theme, but it isn't possible to capture that entire history.
- FAIR Principles:
 - F - findable: data and meta data should be easy to find.
 - A - accessible: users should know how to access it.
 - I - interoperable: data should work with other datasets/tools.
 - R - reusable: data should be well-described so others can use it.
- CARE Principles (Indigenous Data Governance):
 - C - collective benefit: data should benefit communities.
 - A - authority to control: communities should have control over their data.
 - R - responsibility: researchers have responsibilities to communities.
 - E - ethics: data should be handled ethically.

Think piece: "Attracted by the Khaki"

- Examines fears of prostitution/sex work near WWI military camps in Virginia.
- Focuses on Bon Air and Peake's Turnout as two female reformatories (one white, one POC).
- Data was collected to argue for the funding and expansion of institutions.
- Shows how data can represent working/low-income women and broader social changes like urbanization.
- Some issues I discovered while exploring the project:

- The map system used actually showed me a 404 error; therefore, I couldn't see the visual display of data. The map was important as it was explaining that the majority of prostitution occurred in rural areas and not in suburban one's as the city assumed it would due to the placement of the training camps. However, I couldn't verify this for myself as I couldn't see the map. This goes against the "A" in FAIR.
- I couldn't find any public data on the website. I assumed I was looking for numbers of research (as things were plotted on a graph). This goes against the "F" in FAIR.
- With this in mind, I learned the importance of:
 - Making data clear and clearly defining why you are using your data and where.
 - Digital things expire!
 - Somehow, humanitarian research can be turned into quantifiable data.

Class Notes:

- Data: the information collected.
- Metadata: information describing the data.
- Paradata: information about how/why the data was created and decisions made during the process.
- Turning your life into data:
 - Identify: what information about yourself "counts"?
 - Describe: what goes in/out of the dataset?
 - Collect: gather information consistently.
 - Clean: standardize the data, but also consider what gets lost.
 - Relates to my prior example of studying English Kings in a certain frame... know what data you are intentionally not putting in (and why.)
 - Analyze: what patterns/stories emerge?
 - Distribute: who should have access?
- Key idea: Data cleaning and categorization are not neutral; they can change what the dataset represents.
- Collection Builder:
 - Digital humanities tool for creating digital collections and storytelling.
 - Uses metadata tables and long-form storytelling.
 - To do:
 - Explain what the tool does.
 - Walk through the tutorial.
 - Identify the tutorial's "gotcha's"/limitations
 - Consider what those limitations reveal about assumptions in digital humanities
 - Connect the tool to your own research

- Takeaway: Data is constructed, not neutral. What we collect, how we organize it, and who can access it, all shape the historical stories we can tell.